Notified in 2006 in 200 districts, the flagship programme today is implemented in ***all districts*** with rural areas. For 2012-13 the total outlay was Rs. 33,000 crore – 4.39 crore households have been provided employment of 156.01 crore persondays of which 82.58 crore *(53 per cent)* were availed by women, 34.56 crore *(22 per cent)* by SCs, and 24.90 crore *(16 per cent)* by STs.

At the national level, with the average wage paid under the MGNREGA increasing from Rs. 65 in 2006-7 to Rs. 115 in 2011-12, the ***bargaining power*** of agricultural labour has increased as even private sector wages have increased as shown in many studies (said by the *MGNREGA Sameeksha 2012*). Improved economic outcomes, especially in watershed activities, and reduction in distress migration are its other achievements. Wages under the MGNREGA are indexed to the consumer price index for agricultural labour *(CPI-AL).*

As per the latest *Economic Survey 2012-13* (which quotes the Ministry for Rural Development), the GoI has taken the following new initiatives to make MGNREGA effective and focused –

(i) The basket of permissible activities has been expanded to make it more meaningful.

(ii) Electronic Fund Management System (eFMS) in all states has been initiated in a phased manner to reduce delay in payment of wages.

(iii) Additional employment over and above 100 days per household in notified drought-affected talukas/blocks is now permissible.

(iv) Provision has been made for seeding in Aadhaar into the MGNREGA workers records to prevent leakage.

(v) Convergence of the MGNREGA with the Total Sanitation Campaign (TSC) has been undertaken.

The *Survey* further adds, ‘with better planning of project design, capacity building of panchayati raj institutions (PRIs), skill upgradation for enhanced employability, and reduction of transaction costs, gaps in implementation could be plugged to a greater extent and the assets so created could make a much larger contribution to increasing land productivity’.